Rakhine State. In contrast to political parties from other ethnic groups who were unable to form a united political front in the 2015 election, the ANP was reported as the united front gaining an exceptional level of support from the Rakhine constituency. The popular support among the Buddhist Rakhine for their leaders' strong stance against the Muslim communities and the prevalence of public perception that the NLD was pro-Muslim were also identified as key reasons for the Rakhine State electoral exceptionalism.

However, the ANP victory was not as comprehensive as it might first appear to have been. It lost all townships of Thandwe District to the NLD, and gained most of its seats with small margins, with a large majority of votes only in Sittwe District.[1] The exclusion of most Muslim voters in the northern district of Maungdaw resulted in shared electoral victories between the ANP and the Tatmadaw-established Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP). The differences in voting patterns and election results showed support was not uniform across the state. A detailed analysis of the electoral results at the constituency level can show the reasons for these differences, and give insights into the influence that ethnicity and Buddhist nationalism have among the Rakhine. Moreover, the Rakhine State situation can be juxtaposed with other parts of Myanmar and the NLD wins, shedding light on the reason for the overall rather insignificant effect of Buddhist nationalism on the 2015 elections.

As this chapter aims to put the Rakhine State electoral results in the national context of the NLD's landslide victory, in the next section I outline how the election outcome was predicted and then explained by most analysts, especially in relation to ethnicity and Buddhist nationalism. In the subsequent section I discuss the ideological origins of the ANP to show that it is the manifestation of a long history of Rakhine ethno-nationalism despite being less than two years old. Then, I present detailed information on voting patterns in Rakhine State to show that the ANP support is strongest in northern townships, and gradually weakens towards the south. The final section discusses the ANP as a credible alternative to the NLD in Rakhine State, while the USDP was not a credible alternative in the whole of Myanmar. The electoral results in Rakhine State showed the relative influence of Buddhist nationalism in Myanmar, and the electoral victory of the NLD should not under-emphasize this influence in understanding Myanmar's politics and society.